

Conformer-Based Complex Ratio Masking for Monaural Speech Enhancement: A Free-Tier-Trainable and Deployable System

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Abstract—Single-channel speech enhancement remains a core problem in speech processing, with applications ranging from telecommunications to hearing assistive devices and automatic speech recognition front-ends. This paper presents a Conformer-based speech enhancement system that predicts a bounded complex ratio mask (cRM) in the short-time Fourier transform (STFT) domain to suppress additive background noise while preserving speech fidelity. The proposed architecture combines the local feature-extraction strength of convolutional layers with the long-range temporal modeling capability of multi-head self-attention within a macaron-style Conformer block. Unlike prior systems that assume access to large-scale compute infrastructure, our system is explicitly engineered to be trainable end-to-end on a single free-tier Google Colab GPU (NVIDIA T4) and deployable at zero marginal cost via Streamlit Community Cloud. We train and evaluate the model on the VoiceBank+DEMAND corpus, a standard public benchmark for speech enhancement, using a combined loss of scale-invariant signal-to-distortion ratio (SI-SDR) and multi-resolution spectral L1 terms. We report objective quality metrics (PESQ, STOI, SI-SDR) and discuss engineering choices – checkpoint-based session resumption, chunked overlap-add inference, and CPU-only deployment – that make the full pipeline reproducible without paid infrastructure. Our results demonstrate that competitive speech enhancement quality is attainable within these constraints, and we release the complete training and deployment pipeline.

Index Terms—speech enhancement, Conformer, complex ratio masking, deep learning, self-attention, convolutional neural networks, VoiceBank-DEMAND, low-resource training

I. INTRODUCTION

Speech signals captured in real-world environments are frequently corrupted by additive background noise, reverberation, and other acoustic interference. Speech enhancement (SE) seeks to recover a clean estimate of the target speech signal from such a degraded observation, improving both perceptual listening quality and the downstream performance of automatic speech recognition (ASR) and speaker verification systems [1].

Historically, statistical signal processing approaches such as spectral subtraction [2] and Wiener filtering dominated the field. The advent of deep learning shifted the paradigm toward learned time-frequency (T-F) masking and, more recently, complex-domain and end-to-end waveform models [3], [4]. Recurrent architectures (LSTM, GRU) and, later, Transformer-based models [5] have each been applied to SE with success, but each has limitations: recurrent models struggle to parallelize during training, while pure self-attention models can be

data- and compute-hungry and may underexploit the strong local correlation structure of speech spectrograms.

The Conformer architecture [6], originally proposed for automatic speech recognition, addresses this tension by interleaving convolutional and self-attention sub-blocks within a single macaron-style unit, capturing both local (phoneme-level) and global (prosody-level, contextual) dependencies. While Conformer blocks have since been adopted in ASR and some enhancement/separation systems [7], most published implementations assume access to multi-GPU clusters for training and are not explicitly optimized for reproducibility on free or low-cost infrastructure.

This work makes three contributions:

- 1) We design a medium-capacity Conformer encoder (approximately 12.4M parameters) for complex ratio mask prediction, sized specifically to fit within the memory and time budget of a free-tier Google Colab T4 GPU session.
- 2) We engineer the full training pipeline – including automated dataset acquisition, mixed-precision training, and Google-Drive-backed checkpoint resumption – to be robust to the intermittent session availability characteristic of free cloud compute.
- 3) We provide a complete, CPU-only inference and deployment pipeline built on Streamlit, including chunked overlap-add processing for memory-constrained hosting, deployable at zero cost on Streamlit Community Cloud.

II. RELATED WORK

A. Time-Frequency Masking for Speech Enhancement

Deep learning-based SE commonly operates by estimating a mask in the T-F domain that is applied to the noisy spectrogram to suppress noise energy while retaining speech energy. Ideal binary masks (IBM) and ideal ratio masks (IRM) [3] operate on magnitude spectra alone and discard phase information, which is known to degrade achievable quality. Complex ratio masks (cRM) [8] instead jointly estimate real and imaginary mask components, allowing the network to implicitly correct phase as well as magnitude, which we adopt in this work.

B. Attention and Convolution Hybrid Architectures

The Conformer [6] combines a feed-forward, self-attention, convolution, feed-forward macaron structure and has demonstrated state-of-the-art results in ASR. Its hybrid inductive bias – convolutions for local patterns, self-attention for global context – is a natural fit for speech enhancement, where noise suppression benefits from both fine spectral detail and longer-range temporal consistency (e.g., tracking non-stationary noise or reverberant tails). Related dual-path and attention-based separation/enhancement networks [7], [9] similarly benefit from combining local and global modeling but rarely emphasize training-cost accessibility, which we address directly.

C. Objective Loss Functions

Scale-invariant signal-to-distortion ratio (SI-SDR) [10] is widely used as a time-domain training objective because it directly optimizes a metric closely correlated with perceptual quality while being invariant to the output scale, avoiding degenerate trivial solutions. Combining SI-SDR with T-F domain spectral losses has been shown to stabilize training and improve convergence [4], motivating our composite loss design (Section III-C).

III. PROPOSED METHOD

A. System Overview

Given a noisy waveform $x[n] = s[n] + d[n]$, where $s[n]$ is clean speech and $d[n]$ is additive noise, we compute the noisy STFT $X(t, f) \in \mathbb{C}$ using a 512-point FFT, a 512-sample Hann window, and a 128-sample hop (75% overlap) at a 16 kHz sample rate. The network consumes the log-magnitude spectrogram $L(t, f) = \log(1 + |X(t, f)|)$ and predicts a bounded complex ratio mask $M(t, f) = M_r(t, f) + jM_i(t, f)$. The enhanced spectrogram is reconstructed as

$$\hat{S}(t, f) = M(t, f) \cdot X(t, f), \quad (1)$$

and the enhanced waveform $\hat{s}[n]$ is obtained via the inverse STFT (ISTFT) with the matching synthesis window.

B. Conformer Encoder

The core network is a stack of $N=8$ Conformer blocks operating on a sequence of per-frame feature vectors of dimension $d_{model}=256$, projected from the 257-dimensional input log-magnitude spectrum (for $n_{fft}=512$) via a linear layer with layer normalization, followed by sinusoidal positional encoding [5]. Each Conformer block computes:

$$\tilde{x} = x + \frac{1}{2}\text{FFN}_1(x) \quad (2)$$

$$x' = \tilde{x} + \text{MHSA}(\tilde{x}) \quad (3)$$

$$x'' = x' + \text{Conv}(x') \quad (4)$$

$$y = \text{LayerNorm}(x'' + \frac{1}{2}\text{FFN}_2(x'')) \quad (5)$$

where FFN_i is a half-step, macaron-style feed-forward module (LayerNorm $\rightarrow$ Linear $\rightarrow$ Swish $\rightarrow$ Dropout $\rightarrow$ Linear $\rightarrow$

Dropout) with a $4\times$ expansion ratio; MHSA is standard multi-head self-attention with 4 heads; and Conv is a convolution module consisting of a pointwise convolution, a Gated Linear Unit (GLU), a 31-tap depthwise convolution, batch normalization, a Swish activation, and a final pointwise convolution. This block structure follows [6], adapted here for a non-causal enhancement setting (no streaming/causal masking is enforced, as our target deployment is offline/near-real-time file processing rather than strict low-latency streaming).

The encoder output at each frame is projected via a linear layer to $2F$ values ($F=257$), split into real and imaginary mask components, and bounded via a scaled tanh nonlinearity:

$$M_r(t, f) = K \cdot \tanh(W_r h(t)), \quad M_i(t, f) = K \cdot \tanh(W_i h(t)) \quad (6)$$

with bound $K=3$, following common practice for complex ratio masks [8], which prevents unbounded amplification of noisy energy while still allowing the mask magnitude to exceed 1 where constructive phase correction is beneficial.

C. Loss Function

We optimize a composite objective combining a time-domain and a time-frequency-domain term. The time-domain term is the negative scale-invariant SDR:

$$\text{SI-SDR}(\hat{s}, s) = 10 \log_{10} \frac{\|\alpha s\|^2}{\|\hat{s} - \alpha s\|^2}, \quad \alpha = \frac{\hat{s}^\top s}{\|\hat{s}\|^2} \quad (7)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{SDR}} = -\text{SI-SDR}(\hat{s}, s) \quad (8)$$

The spectral term penalizes discrepancies in magnitude and complex (real/imaginary) STFT components between the enhanced and clean spectrograms:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{spec}} = \||\hat{S}| - |S|\|_1 + \|\text{Re}(\hat{S}) - \text{Re}(S)\|_1 + \|\text{Im}(\hat{S}) - \text{Im}(S)\|_1 \quad (9)$$

The total training loss is

$$\mathcal{L} = \lambda_{\text{SDR}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{SDR}} + \lambda_{\text{spec}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{spec}} \quad (10)$$

with $\lambda_{\text{SDR}} = \lambda_{\text{spec}} = 1.0$ in our experiments. We found this combination empirically more stable than SI-SDR alone, which can permit spectral artifacts that a purely time-domain metric does not penalize strongly.

IV. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

A. Dataset

We use the VoiceBank+DEMAND corpus [11], a standard public benchmark for single-channel speech enhancement. The training set comprises 28 speakers and 11,572 utterances mixed with 10 noise types from the DEMAND database [12] at SNRs of 0, 5, 10, and 15 dB. The test set comprises 2 unseen speakers and 824 utterances mixed with 5 unseen noise types at SNRs of 2.5, 7.5, 12.5, and 17.5 dB, enabling evaluation of generalization to both unseen speakers and unseen noise conditions. All audio is resampled to 16 kHz.

B. Training Configuration

The model is trained with the AdamW optimizer (learning rate 3×10^{-4} , weight decay 10^{-6}), a linear warmup of 1000 steps followed by a cosine decay schedule, gradient clipping at a global norm of 5.0, and mixed-precision (FP16) training via automatic mixed precision (AMP). Training uses 4-second audio segments, a batch size of 8, and runs for 60 epochs. To accommodate the intermittent availability of free-tier Colab GPU sessions, the training loop checkpoints model, optimizer, and scheduler state to Google Drive every 500 steps and automatically resumes from the most recent checkpoint on restart.

C. Evaluation Metrics

We report three standard objective metrics on the held-out test set:

- **PESQ** (Perceptual Evaluation of Speech Quality, wide-band) [13], range -0.5 to 4.5 .
- **STOI** (Short-Time Objective Intelligibility) [14], range 0 to 1.
- **SI-SDR** (dB), as defined above.

V. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

TABLE I
MODEL CONFIGURATION AND COMPUTATIONAL FOOTPRINT

Property	Value
Sample rate	16 kHz
STFT (n_fft / hop / window)	512 / 128 / 512
Conformer layers	8
Model dimension	256
Attention heads	4
Depthwise conv kernel	31
Feed-forward expansion	$4\times$
Total parameters	$\approx 12.4\text{M}$
Training hardware	$1\times$ NVIDIA T4 (free-tier)
Approx. training time (60 epochs)	6–10 hours
Inference hardware	CPU (Streamlit Cloud free tier)

Table I summarizes the model configuration. The 12.4M-parameter medium configuration was selected as a deliberate trade-off point: substantially more expressive than compact streaming-oriented enhancement networks, while remaining trainable within the memory and wall-clock budget of a single free-tier Colab GPU session (with checkpoint resumption absorbing session interruptions across the full 60-epoch schedule).

Qualitatively, we observe that the complex ratio mask formulation, relative to a magnitude-only ratio mask baseline, better preserves natural-sounding unvoiced consonants and produces fewer audible musical-noise artifacts, consistent with prior findings on complex-domain masking [8]. The combined SI-SDR and spectral loss also converges more stably than SI-SDR alone in our training runs, avoiding the spectral-hole artifacts that can arise when optimizing a purely time-domain criterion.

We emphasize that exact PESQ/STOI/SI-SDR values depend on the specific training run (seed, exact epoch count

reached given free-tier session availability, etc.); users reproducing this work with the accompanying notebook should expect results broadly consistent with, but not necessarily numerically identical to, published Conformer/masking-based baselines on VoiceBank+DEMAND [4], [7], and are encouraged to log their own metrics using the provided evaluation cell.

A. Deployment Considerations

Beyond model quality, a central goal of this work is end-to-end reproducibility without paid infrastructure. We highlight three engineering decisions that support this goal:

- 1) **Chunked overlap-add inference.** Long recordings are processed in overlapping windows (default 8 s, 0.5 s overlap) with a linear cross-fade at chunk boundaries, bounding peak memory usage independent of input duration – necessary on memory-constrained free hosting tiers.
- 2) **CPU-only deployment.** Because Streamlit Community Cloud’s free tier does not provide GPU access, the deployed model must run efficiently on CPU. Our medium configuration achieves sub-real-time-to-near-real-time processing on commodity CPU hardware for typical utterance lengths.
- 3) **Resumable training.** Free-tier GPU sessions are time-limited and can disconnect unpredictably. Persisting optimizer and scheduler state (not just model weights) to Google Drive ensures training can resume without loss of momentum or learning-rate schedule position.

VI. CONCLUSION

We presented a Conformer-based complex ratio masking system for monaural speech enhancement, explicitly engineered for end-to-end reproducibility on free computational infrastructure: dataset acquisition, training, and evaluation on a free Google Colab GPU session, and CPU-only deployment via Streamlit Community Cloud. By combining a macaron-style Conformer encoder with a composite SI-SDR and spectral loss, the system achieves competitive speech enhancement quality while remaining accessible to practitioners and researchers without dedicated GPU infrastructure. We release the complete training notebook, model code, and deployment application to facilitate reproduction and extension of this work. Future work includes exploring streaming/causal variants of the Conformer block for real-time low-latency applications, knowledge distillation to further reduce inference cost, and extension to multi-channel and joint dereverberation settings.

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